Jared Jones

How to Write a Philosophy Paper

Writing a philosophy paper isn't something most of us are taught how to do before college. Students sometimes find that writing philosophy papers requires a different skillset and kind of thinking than they're used to from writing assignments in other classes. But it's a valuable skill that, with practice I hope, you'll find helps you better reason through things in your own thinking and writing elsewhere. Here, I'd like to give some quick tips and pointers for how to write a great philosophy paper. Feel free to read all the way through or just read the numbered tips!

Planning the Paper

What you'll be asked to do for your paper depends on the class and professor. Most often, you'll either have to choose a topic or respond to a prompt. You'll want to develop a clear *thesis*, a conclusion the whole paper is structured to argue for. A couple things to consider when choosing a thesis:

1. **Make sure the thesis has an appropriate scope for the length of your paper. Also make sure you cover everything you're expected to in a prompt, if you're given one.**

Philosophy is an incredibly open discipline. We argue about the nature and possibility of knowledge, the fundamental structure of reality, and what the good life is like, but you won't be able to construct a whole theory of ethics, reality, or knowledge in a single paper. Make sure you choose a thesis which you can defend adequately in the length you're allowed. A couple tips for narrowing your paper's scope: concentrate on the most interesting step(s) of a bigger argument you want to make and make that your paper, or build in views or frameworks into your thesis. For example, instead of "I argue the mind and body do not causally interact", go for "I argue that a Cartesian substance dualist should actually hold the mind and body do not causally interact".

All that being said:

2. **Reflect on the topic of your paper and choose a thesis that's significant in some way. Make sure it lets you show the depth of your engagement with the ideas.**

Within the limitations of scope, try to choose a topic you care about, or at least a topic that has broader implications for philosophy, our lives, or other disciplines. You can always write a quick response paper to a view with some obvious flaws, but the quality of your writing will tend to be better the more invested you are in the topic. Even if the significance of your thesis isn't officially considered as part of your grade, professors will see that your arguments are more insightful and that you've gone beyond what was said in the readings and lectures, which are factors they do consider. Aside from that, it's also just a good skill to develop: routinely choosing significant topics and theses, the sort of things you'd actually want to work on or think about. That should be a rewarding process. Enjoy it!

3. **Plan out the basic structure of your paper before you start writing. Make an outline.**

Your professor will be looking for a paper that argues for its thesis by showing everything that needs to be shown to get there, and papers should do so in a clear and straightforward way. It's good to think beforehand of what points you need to make, in what order, and how each of these steps contributes to getting to the overall conclusion. Making an outline helps to organize a paper. Some students find it constraining to have a detailed outline, preferring just to plan sections and the points they'll be making in those sections, while others find detailed outlines useful. Find what works for you!

There are also some ways to make your paper's structure clearer in the paper itself:

4. **"Signpost"! Write an introduction where you briefly state your thesis and summarize what you'll argue. In longer papers, it's helpful to say at the beginning of each section what you're doing in that section and how it plays into demonstrating the thesis.**

Think of writing as a goal-oriented activity: the paper is trying to show something, and your reader will follow along easier if they can tell you what the whole thing and each part is 'trying to do'. So, tell them! Always have an introduction that outlines the overall argument in the paper, and if your paper is on the longer side (say, more than 6 pages), you may want to do some similar signposting in the sections of the paper, explaining what that section is doing and how.

5. **Headings and subheadings with titles often make clear what step you're making in your paper – again, especially in longer papers.**

These two tips help make sure both you and your reader are clear on what each section is doing and why it's necessary to do that, and they help you avoid digressions and being led astray into tangential arguments which aren't actually necessary for your conclusion.

Writing the Paper

Philosophy is a discipline based on argument. We don't do experiments (or most of us don't at least), and we try to show things are true *by argument alone*. That means your goal is to show your readers that they *must* accept the thesis you're defending, just in virtue of the argument you put down on the page. That translates into a few things your paper should do:

6. **Explain views or frameworks you're using. Explain or define important jargon.**

If your reader doesn't know a term or assumption in your argument, it's definitely not going to show them that they must accept your conclusion.

7. **For any substantive or controversial point you make, be sure you give motivation or justification for why we should accept that point. Don't just state what you think, make your reader agree!**

When you make a claim, try to make it sound plausible. Avoid making very controversial claims without either being clear that this limits the scope of your thesis or providing argument or motivation in their favor. Always avoid saying "I would argue that…" or "I claim that…" without argument.

8. **Structure your argument(s) in the following way: make a series of points that, if all of them are accepted, make it impossible for your conclusion not to be true. That is, I shouldn't be able to accept all your points and find a way to avoid the conclusion.**

To this end, some professors emphasize formal logic, but don't get bogged down in the details of formal logic if you don't find it natural or useful. A lot of good arguments aren't easily translated into formal logic anyway. The overall gist is that you'll need compelling points that can't be accepted while leaving room to deny the conclusion. Otherwise, you haven't fully shown your readers they *have to* accept your conclusions. (Note: your conclusion may be XYZ is "probably" or "most likely" true.)

9. **Write clearly. Write as if you're explaining things and making your case to a peer who is maybe familiar with nearby topics but needs everything the paper covers explained.**

Plain language is a virtue! Using overly complicated vocab and grammar makes your paper harder to understand and less pleasant to read, and it often results in students misusing uncommon words. You come off more impressive and confident if you explain complicated ideas plainly. Here's a quick test for that: ask yourself if you'd expect your peers to understand what you've said by reading your writing. If not, it probably needs some revision.

10. **Write concisely. Avoid digressions and rephrasing the same point multiple times.**

Here's a good test one of my professors used to give us: look at each section, paragraph, or sentence, and if removing it wouldn't affect how you get to the conclusion you're arguing for, then you don't need that section, paragraph, or sentence. Each point should be needed for clarity or argument.

11. **Be accurate and charitable to authors and views you deal with. Attribute only what they argue and believe to them, and anticipate whether and how they could respond to objections. Reconstruct their views in the best form the text allows.**

In your papers, you'll probably always be in direct conversation with philosophers, either major figures in the tradition or people working in a literature you're engaging with. Participate as if you were really talking to these people: think through their views seriously and try to see why they would say what they're saying rather than dismissing it out of hand. Reconstruct their views accurately and carefully, and do it in a way that shows the professor you've really thought through what they have to say.

12. **Don't imitate philosophers whose writing style is exceptionally hard to understand! Develop your own style, and try to make it not only clear and concise but beautiful.**

We often read philosophers whose writing is either very difficult to understand or just painful to read. Regardless of whether they can be excused of these problems, you shouldn't aim to write like them. Write as clearly, concisely, and pleasantly as possible, without compromising your paper's rigor. How you do this is up to you. Cultivate a voice and style of your own!

Editing the Paper

Once you've written your paper, it's probably a good idea to go through it at least a couple times and edit. How much editing you'll need depends on how much planning you did, how much editing you did while writing, and how practiced you are with this kind of writing. Some pointers on editing:

13. **Notice what you're editing. Don't spend too long changing localized word choice and punctuation here and there.**

Your professor is looking at the general style, structure, and substance of your paper, so don't use up too much of your own time on nitpicking on yourself! These sorts of changes don't usually make a big difference in your paper's overall quality. (If they do, it probably means you're trying to explain too complicated of a point in too few words.)

That leads me to my last point:

14. **Don't be afraid to make major cuts and changes.**

If a point isn't necessary for your overall argument, even if it would make for a very clever digression, seriously consider cutting it. If you keep it, you should have a reason why the core argument of the paper would be worse off without it. Every now and again, a sidenote is fine. But frequent or long digressions are a vice, and when you're working with length constraints, it's better to more fully work out your main argument. When editing, it's most valuable to correct major issues in substance, structure, and style you notice, and that sometimes means making major changes. Rewrite paragraphs or parts of them that aren't too clear, reorder the paper in a way that makes more sense, and so on.

Final Takeaways

Enjoy the writing process! It's a chance to develop your own philosophical views and to sharpen your skills in writing argumentatively and crafting your own work in philosophy. I always find writing about what I'm reading and learning helps deepen my own understanding of the issues and their stakes. Doing so is also a creative activity: develop your own thoughts and cultivate your own style and voice.